

deletion, and the server is configured such that it deletes such messages at regular intervals.

If J regularly received hundreds of mails a day, he could have issued a command to view messages that met certain criteria (such as “smaller than 10 KB). Messages on the server can be marked with status flags such as “answered”.

In contrast, Q returns home from a busy day and turns on his PC. He clicks on “Receive Mail” in his mail program. All his mails come to his hard disk, and are gone from the Internet. Now, if Q goes to a cyber-café and opens up a similar mail program to fetch his mail, nothing will show up.

That’s the typical scenario, but actually, POP3 *does* allow you to keep messages on the server—it’s just a simple setting in the mail program. So, for example, Q might open the mail program at a cyber-café and set it to leave messages on the server. He’d then download his messages, read them, then delete them (so that the next user at his seat won’t get to read them). Then, he goes home, where his mail program is *not* set to leave messages on the server; when he downloads the mail there, it’ll be saved to his hard disk and erased from the server.

So, then, which do you like: IMAP or POP3 or Webmail?

6.3 The Choices

The answer to that question depends on several factors. Ask yourself the following, not in order of importance:

- How fast is my Internet connection?
- On what basis do I pay for my Net connection?
- Do I want to read and write mails when not connected?
- On how many computers do I check my mail?
- Is there a limit on the storage at the mail server?
- Do I have the habit of making backups?
- Is it possible for others to get at my mail?
- Does it feel better reading mail without external content garlanding it?
- Do I have a choice between POP3 and IMAP with my ISP?
- Do I have a choice between POP3 and Webmail at work?